This story, of Prince Ashoka and Devi is, like many other romantic liaisons of antiquity, an account of unsatisfactory brevity. She was the daughter of a prominent city merchant in Vidisha, this we know, but she is otherwise an elusive figure. Nothing is known of her early life or upbringing or even about her persona before she encountered Ashoka, except that she was, like most future queens, extraordinarily pretty before becoming one. As we saw in the story around Bindusara and the Brahman girl from Champa (later Ashoka's mother), royal men have the habit of noticing female commoners only when they are arrestingly beautiful. Bindusara's son seems to have been in his father's mould. And, naturally, the texts would have us believe it was love at first sight.



Fig. 4.2: The Malwa plateau's hills and forests as they appear near Bhimbetka

Also in line with the template, it is less the state of the heart than the reproductive outcome of this affair of the heart which is central to the story. The *Dipavamsa* puts it blandly: 'the daughter of a Setthi (or merchant),